

Hospitality Perspectives No. 04

Who Do We See Standing Before Us?

Luxury hospitality is often associated with beautiful architecture, elegant interiors and exceptional service. Yet some of the most important decisions made in a hotel are neither financial nor operational. They are human.

Over the years, I have come to believe that lasting commercial performance is rarely built through numbers alone. Revenue is essential to every successful hotel and resort, but it is often the result of decisions made long before the guest checks out.

Relationships determine what happens next.

Revenue tells us what happened.

Earlier in my career, I worked within a highly seasonal destination resort. Like many resort operations around the world, every season brought a familiar challenge. New employees arrived, training began, confidence slowly developed, and just as many team members were becoming comfortable in their roles, the season came to an end. The knowledge, experience and judgement that had been carefully built often left with them.

From a guest's perspective, none of those operational realities were visible.

Guests did not see recruitment challenges, training schedules, staff turnover or seasonal employment. They experienced only one simple question:

Was someone able to help me when it mattered?

That experience shaped my thinking.

At first glance, it is easy to conclude that employees simply need to be more empowered. But empowerment is rarely something management announces in a handbook. It is something that is built over time through trust, confidence and leadership.

When leaders begin to see each guest and each employee as a person rather than a transaction or a resource, the organisation itself begins to behave differently.

Managers often speak about serving guests. Equally important is recognising that leadership also exists to support the people who care for those guests every day. Respect cannot be demanded simply because of a job title. It is earned through consistent behaviour, fairness and genuine care for the people who represent the organisation.

When seasonal employees feel trusted, respected and supported, something interesting begins to happen.

They return.

Returning seasonal employees do far more than fill vacancies. They return with confidence, local knowledge, organisational culture and the judgement that only experience can develop. They require less supervision, exercise better judgement and naturally create more consistent guest experiences.

Guests notice the difference.**Not because service becomes perfect.****Because they feel understood.**

Meaningful conversations, thoughtful problem solving and genuine care are rarely remembered as isolated service moments. Together they become something much more valuable: trust. That trust becomes loyalty, and loyalty becomes repeat visitation.

Hospitality has long understood that retaining a loyal guest is often less costly than continually acquiring a new one. The same principle applies to employees. Organisations that earn the loyalty of their people are far better positioned to earn the loyalty of their guests.

The future is built by leaders who patiently develop people through trust, respect and personal example, giving them the confidence to exercise good judgement.

Technology, systems and performance reports all have an important place in modern hospitality. They support better decisions, but they cannot replace professional judgement or meaningful human relationships.

Every successful hotel measures revenue.**The best hotels understand what creates it.**

Perhaps the most important decision made in a hotel is not financial or operational after all.

It is deciding who we see standing before us.

Hospitality has always been, and I believe will always remain, a business built on people first. Commercial success is not separate from that principle.

It is one of its natural consequences.

About Hospitality Perspectives

Hospitality Perspectives is an independent publication series exploring leadership, commercial performance, destination ecosystems and the evolving future of hospitality. Each publication is intended to encourage thoughtful discussion among hospitality professionals and support better-informed strategic decision-making.

Walton Hospitality Initiative

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